

NEW TRUTH ABOUT ASPIRIN



Too much Aspirin led to a high death toll during the 1918-19 flu pandemic. That's the latest verdict from medical researchers, reported in the current issue of *Clinical Infectious Diseases*. The suggestion?

Avoiding high doses of

Aspirin is crucial given the current H1N1 flu pandemic. Too much of it causes a series of events that disrupt the body's metabolism. And the effect eventually leads to dysfunction at a cellular level. Autopsy reports from 1918 consistently show Aspirin toxicity as well as the expected viral causes of death. Aspirin is present in a wide array of medicines sold over the counter. So beware. Don't overdose on Aspirin to treat flu-like symptoms.

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LAKH BABIES DIE WITHIN THE FIRST 24 HOURS OF LIFE IN INDIA EVERY YEAR.

Smoked Out

Smoking may lead to memory decline, reports the *Journal of Neurology, Neurosurgery and Psychiatry*. Current smokers are 70 per cent more likely to develop dementia and cognitive impairment than those who have never smoked. So stub it out, if you're still in love with nicotine.

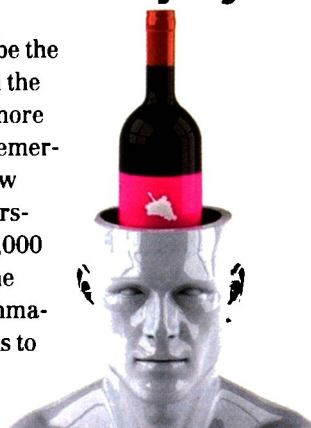
Safety Training as Commonwealth Nears



The first 10 minutes matter the most in any emergency—accidents, stampedes, natural disasters, terrorist attacks, earthquake or fire outbreaks. And when about 30 per cent of the population is trained in everyday safety issues, the chances of survival rise considerably, say experts. No wonder the Commonwealth Games Committee is training ground volunteers in emergency management. Philanthrope, a non-profit organisation entrusted with the critical task, is busy on the job and has offered to train up 30,000 volunteers free of cost by 2010.

Alcohol May Help Survive Head Injury

If you take a tumble on your head, a stiff drink might just be the thing you need. At least a new study says so. The report in the *New Scientist* claims that alcohol in blood makes people more likely to survive head injuries—and this could make it an emergency treatment. More research is needed to establish how alcohol protects the brain, but researchers from the Cedars-Sinai Medical Centre in Los Angeles, US—who studied 38,000 people with head injuries—say it may work by blunting the amount of adrenaline reaching the brain, reducing inflammation. Before you do anything about it, remember, alcohol is to blame for half of all traffic-related fatalities in the world.



Dubious Distinction



With about 41 million patients, India is the diabetes capital of the world, followed by China and the US. After smoking, diabetes is the main cause of heart disease in India; the onset of diabetes among Indians is early compared to the West; most Indians do not achieve the treatment goals as per international guidelines; have poor 'laboratory' and 'self-monitoring' of blood glucose levels; and, to top it all, have an indifferent attitude to the disease. All that and more have been reported by a five-year-long, ongoing study of diabetes on 1,755 patients by healthcare major, Sanofi-Aventis. Hardly a surprise then that India continues to top the diabetes charts despite all efforts.

■ Compiled by **Damayanti Datta**